

Diprotodon

die-PRO-toe-don

- **When** 2 million–40,000 years ago (Neogene)
- **Fossil location** Australia
- **Habitat** Forest and scrubland
- **Length** 10 ft (3 m)
- **Diet** Plants

Also known as the giant wombat, rhinoceros-sized *Diprotodon* was the largest marsupial known. A plant-eater, it survived on a mixture of rough leaves and grasses and may have lived in herds. Fossils of female *Diprotodons* carrying young reveal that babies' pouches opened toward the rear, unlike the forward-facing pouches of



kangaroos. *Diprotodon* disappeared shortly after humans first colonized Australia. Some scientists think it was hunted to extinction for its meat, though others blame loss of forest as Australia's climate gradually became more dry.



LIVING RELATIVE

Kangaroos are the largest living marsupials and are found only in Australia and New Guinea. A kangaroo baby (a "joey") is the size of a jellybean when born and is blind, deaf, hairless, and has no back legs. It

squirms into its mother's pouch and stays there for up to eight months, suckling from a nipple, until it develops fully.



Argyrolagus

ar-JYE-roe-LAY-gus

- **When** 23–2 million years ago (Paleogene–Neogene)
- **Fossil location** S. America
- **Habitat** Desert
- **Length** 1 ft (0.4 m)
- **Diet** Plants

Argyrolagus fossils dating back to 53 million years ago have been found in South America. This creature looked like a giant kangaroo rat, with



very long hindlimbs and small forelimbs. It probably moved around by hopping, just like a modern kangaroo. Its long tail helped it to keep its balance. *Argyrolagus*'s narrow head had a pointed snout with broad cheek teeth, which it may have used for crushing tough plants and other vegetation. This marsupial had big eyes for seeing in the dark and probably fed at night.



Sinodelphys

SIGH-no-DELF-iss

- **When** 125 million years ago (Early Cretaceous)
- **Fossil location** China
- **Habitat** Woodlands
- **Length** 6 in (15 cm)
- **Diet** Insects and worms

Judging by its teeth and by the bones of its wrists and ankles, this chipmunk-sized tree-dweller was closely related to the first

marsupials, although it wasn't a marsupial itself. The single fossil, found in China in 2003, is well preserved and shows tufts of hair around the bones. *Sinodelphys* was a good climber, with flexible ankle bones—it could rotate its feet backward to climb down trees. It probably scurried around among the branches—safe from predators—chasing after insects.



▲ **KILLER TEETH** Two long, saber-shaped teeth pointed downward from *Thylacosmilus*'s upper jaw. They were protected by tooth guards made of bone.

